

Integrative Theory

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Integrative Approach to Counseling

The basic philosophy of human nature includes many factors such as dysfunction, health and illness, change, and past roles. There are different factors that can cause dysfunction and one of them can come from trauma, social pressure, or not having a support system. Another major role of dysfunction is unresolved conflicts that could have been subconsciously forgotten, if those issues are not resolved early on it can cause a dysfunction as an adult that can affect the individual's cognition and social interactions. The second basic philosophy is health and illness which is how individuals choose to battle through their personal challenges. There are many ways to have a healthy mind and a holistic view promotes well-being in an individual's emotions, mental, and physical state. Whereas an illness is usually cognitive dysfunctional impairments that disturbs emotions or behaviors. An illness can cause an individual to develop maladaptive patterns such as aggression, unhealthy coping mechanisms such as drug abuse, and unhealthy relationships. A person suffering from a mental illness needs a strong support system to help them cope with their internal battles rather than doing it alone. In my philosophy of human nature, people can change whether that is negative or positive is up to the person and their way of facing adversity. People can change when they become self-aware of their good and bad traits, having emotional intelligence is another factor to self-improve. Although change can be difficult because of barriers such as trauma, fearing change, and lack of resources or support systems. Giving the right environment and conditions to an individual can alter their way of thinking and processing feelings and thoughts turning them into positive outcomes.

An approach that caught my attention as a future counselor because it aligns with my beliefs and theory of choice is reality therapy. The reason I chose this theory is because I am a believer that everyone should have a sense of personal responsibility in the choices they make.

According to reality therapy, all behaviors tend to be choices that individuals make for their own needs whether that is for freedom, love, fun, power, love and/or survival. The first key concept of my approach focuses on choice and responsibility and seeing the client being responsible for their actions. Is it important that clients know they have a choice on the present and future rather than the past. Although it is acknowledged it is not recommended to dwell on it because staying in the past will not help move forward and meet the clients needs. The second concept will be to reject transference that way the client and therapist can be themselves in their professional work. By doing this, the client can focus on the present and their own responsibility for their actions or behaviors. My third concept is building rapport with my client and understanding their experiences while acknowledging they are not alone through their battles or responsibilities implementing existential therapy. The fourth concept is goal-oriented to help clients create a specific action plan that has realistic goals they can succeed at that follows through with their beliefs and values as an individual. The last concept in my approach involves self-discovery and helping the client find their own voice. It is important for the client to voice their own concerns, put limits to others, and have effective communication. Being able to have a sense of authenticity and power, will help the clients find their strengths and thrive while also maintaining healthy supportive relationships in which person-centered therapy would be implemented to help them in their journey to self-discovery. Using different types of approaches and integrating them into one can help the therapist have a sense of self that aligns with their values while also helping the client progress through their challenges.

My view of my role as a counselor and the role of the client is to be supportive enough to create a safe space where they feel valued and heard. My main goal is to create an environment where they do not feel judged or ashamed from what they will share during their sessions. It is

important for me to empathize with every client no matter the circumstances because becoming that safe space will create rapport and I will be able to assist them efficiently. I will also establish mutual respect, trust, and professionalism to ensure that the counselor-client relationship is healthy and I can help them grow as an individual. While respect is very important, setting boundaries is equally important. I will do this by establishing boundaries with my client and providing an informed consent form. By doing this I will be ensuring the goals of the session, going over confidentiality and what will be kept private along with exceptions, and professional boundaries such as contacting through social media or public places outside of the clinic, their right to terminate services at any time and the limitations of my services. Providing this form before beginning therapy will establish boundaries and mutual respect from my client and myself as a future counselor. After this has been established, I will continue to be a listening ear to my client while also holding them accountable for their choices given that my approach will rely on reality therapy. However, I will help my client overcome their struggles, progress towards their goal in therapy, and encourage them to a healthy and positive lifestyle.

My therapeutic goals are for clients to positively have coping mechanisms that will benefit their everyday lives. It is important to understand that choices have consequences, and it is up to the client to positively decide on what they will do moving forward. Understanding that the client has wants and needs is also important as a future counselor to help them overcome struggles that might push the client into having negative thoughts. The goals of reality therapy align with the therapeutic goals I plan on implementing as stated by Corey (2017), “a basic goal of reality therapy is to help clients learn better ways of fulfilling all their needs, including achievement, power or inner control, freedom or independence, and fun. The basic human needs serve to focus treatment planning and setting both short- and long-term goals. Reality therapists

assist clients in making more effective and responsible choices related to their wants and needs” (p. 318). These goals align with my values and beliefs, assisting clients in making responsible choices is beneficial for them to thrive in their everyday lives. I would also implement existential therapy goals which are helping them become present to themselves, challenging clients to become a better version of themselves with realistic goals and encouraging them to own their lives and recognize when they have been limiting themselves.

There is various relevant scholarly research that supports my approach of including reality therapy although there are also limitations and criticism to reality therapy. As stated in Corey (2017), “Because reality therapy focuses almost exclusively on consciousness, it does not take into account factors such as repressed conflicts and the power of the unconscious in influencing how we think, feel, behave, and choose” (p. 333). Not looking at an individual's past experiences that have been suppressed can be an indicator of maladaptive behaviors or unpleasant coping mechanisms that are not beneficial to the client. Another interesting limitation on reality therapy according to Wubbolding (2013) is that “reality therapy can lend itself to fixing problems and imposing a therapist’s values on clients, especially by inexperienced or inadequately trained counselors”. This critic is important to acknowledge as a counselor because it can be unethical to impose one's values and beliefs on clients without meaning to but doing so inappropriately. As for supporting research on reality therapy Corey (2017) stated that, “Reality therapy is an effective, short-term approach, often requiring 10 sessions or less, that can enable people to make life changes without prolonged therapy” (p. 333). This is effective because at times individuals want a short-term approach that will help them overcome challenges in their lives and reality therapy offers that approach. Merging with a person-centered approach, an abundance of research supports the notion that the human elements of psychotherapy (client

factors, therapist effects, and the therapeutic alliance) are far more important than models and techniques in the effectiveness and outcomes of therapy (Elkins, 2016). This acknowledges the importance of different factors in therapy and looking at other points of views are essential for an effective therapy session. Lastly, existential therapy has an important limitation that must be acknowledged and according to Sharf (2016), “To a large extent, existential therapy makes use of techniques from other theories, which makes it difficult to apply research to this approach to study its effectiveness”. This is a huge limitation to consider given the fact that in my approach using existential therapy, I will also integrate two more different approaches. On the positive side of existential therapy, as stated by Deurzen (2009), “Existential therapists favor intensity and passionate experience, including that of happiness, but they equally value the darker side of human nature and would encourage clients to learn to value both sides of their experience”. This technique allows clients to feel heard and valued during the time with the therapist. It is essential for the therapist to be empathetic and authentic with clients but also value the dark side of humanity to learn more about the client's personality, behaviors, and environment.

There are various central techniques I am likely to employ come from existential therapy, reality therapy, and person-centered therapy. By merging them together I plan on providing a holistic approach where clients can succeed with their long-term goals and well-being, supporting self-awareness and providing an understanding to the situation the client wants to overcome. Doing this integrative technique will encourage empowerment and a positive change into their lives. Starting off, reality therapy techniques I am likely to use would engage the clients in self-evaluation and ask them questions that stem from the WDEP System which explores their wants, needs, and perception. Asking questions such as “What are you doing to improve your well-being?”, “What do you want in life that needs to be met?”, and “What do you

have to do now to make things happen?”. Providing the opportunity to self-evaluate will give the client time to reflect on their wants and needs and what they are doing to get them. I would also explore their side of values, purpose, and their meaning of life by asking existential questions such as “What do you believe your purpose is?”, “What are values for you and what do they consist of?”, and “What is the meaning of life to you?” These questions will allow me to understand their personality and what they value the most. I will also shift the focus into their own freedom and the responsibility of their own life and how they can choose what they want in life and move forward. Although sometimes the client's choices might not be beneficial, integrating person-centered techniques will allow a safe environment for the therapist and client relationship. This technique will also create a judgement free environment in which I can help the client reflect on their emotions and validate their feelings by showing understanding, authenticity, and having a genuine transparent relationship. Lastly, as a future counselor, I will merge existential, person-centered, and reality therapy in a slow manner to avoid the client from feeling overwhelmed during the therapy session.

The theory I plan on implementing that combines 3 approaches (existential therapy, reality therapy, and person-centered) addresses the issue of cultural diversity. These approaches acknowledged the individual's values, beliefs, experiences, and personality. By combining them together it will value the individual's cultural background and be applied to diverse populations with different values and beliefs. While existential therapy focuses on the individual's meaning of life, freedom, and experience; reality therapy is focused on their needs and wants which are important to every individual no matter their cultural background although they can be expressed in different ways; person-centered therapy is a positive and sympathetic approach that creates a safe space for anyone from a different culture can express themselves without fear of judgement.

Integrating these three approaches will address any issue regarding cultural diversity and make clients feel heard and welcomed.

How Theory Reflects You Personally

My theoretical orientation aligns with my goals, personality, worldview, values, experiences, and vision as a therapist. The reason I chose reality therapy to be my main approach was because I am a firm believer that every action has a consequence. Although not every choice is going to be impactful in a positive way, it is important to take responsibility. This reflected on my values and beliefs that individuals are capable of change, growing, taking responsibility and being authentic to themselves which aligned with existential, person-centered and reality therapy. I value taking accountability of one's actions and meaning to life which makes it easier for me to resonate with existential therapy and help clients go on with their lives and not losing the essence of who they are to their core and their values. Reality therapy aligned with my belief that everyone has different wants and needs and having this belief, I can help clients plan goals that will help them reach their needs and fulfill them while making responsible choices. Person-centered also aligns with my belief of the importance of having positive feedback and a support system that accepts an individual and has empathy for them. My life experiences being a first generation immigrating from Mexico have shaped me into understanding why I am choosing these approaches. Experiencing challenges, adversity and being exposed to a different culture made me aware of my own battles at such a young age. I knew it was important to have a safe space where I would feel valued, heard, and not judged for coming from a different cultural background. At 6 years old, I realized I was experiencing cultural shock and felt like I did not belong where I was. Not being aware that I had to find my own voice, I felt like an outcast with no support system or a counselor to help me navigate my feelings and concerns. This experience,

although I did not know it at the time, shaped me into who I am now. I am an advocate for children who feel like they don't belong, and do not know how to move forward from that feeling. It is extremely hard not being in touch with one's beliefs, values, and culture because I felt lost. Now, I want to be the person who provides a safe environment to future children that feel the same way. First, I would like to implement a person-centered approach and allow the client to feel that I am a safe space, free of judgement and a trusting environment. This approach acknowledges the importance of positive talk, empathy, and authenticity from the counselor to the client. Providing a safe space gives the client the trust and openness to share their concerns by doing this, it will provide the support and resources needed for the individual's personal growth and be able to discover their own voice without shame. I plan on providing an environment where they develop self-acceptance and knowledge that they can be in charge of their own positive changes in life. Then, I would implement an existential approach where I am able to identify the clients' values and get to know them on a deeper level rather than surface level. It is important to identify their way of thinking and the client's belief of what is their purpose in life. By acknowledging their values and meaning of life, I can better assist them on what it is they want to improve on in their lives. This approach will address their own freedom, purpose, and responsibility while empowering them to live a life that will fulfill the clients' needs. Lastly, using reality therapy I can incorporate short- or long-term goals for the client for their needs and help them take responsibility for their choices. I can also help them identify their priorities and what they are doing to obtain them. Using the WDEP system, the client can better understand what they need and what changes need to be made. Doing this will provide self-awareness, accountability, and help the client find solutions to the things they want to change. Integrating these three approaches helps me connect with myself using my own values, beliefs,

and experiences but also provide help to the client regardless of their own beliefs and values.

This approach aligns with my own persona but also gives me the opportunity to help individuals going through the same battles.

Application, Limitations and Strengths

Client group: The integrated approach of existential therapy, reality therapy, and existential therapy is beneficial for clients who want to become self-aware of their behaviors, environment, and personality. By combining these three approaches, clients will be able to also find a purpose to their life, develop problem-solving skills beneficial to their choices and take accountability for their actions. This approach works well with individuals who are at school or working full time that might feel overwhelmed not being able to balance work and their own personal lives; similar to students wanting to balance school and social life to fulfill their wants and needs. The way students and adults can benefit from this integrative approach is by exploring questions from their present while also condensing their past experiences to be able to understand them in a deeper level using existential questions regarding their beliefs and values. Another group that can benefit from this is people who are grieving the loss of a loved one and are having a crisis in their beliefs and their purpose in life. It is important to help clients focus on their values and beliefs to not forget who they are as a person. Lastly, clients from different cultural backgrounds also benefit from this approach since it does value their perspective in life and provide positive support using person-centered techniques.

Counseling setting: This theory can be implemented in different settings such as educational fields (schools), private practice, and community settings that offer free services. For schools whether it is elementary or universities, this approach can support children or young adults by supporting them through their academic years with resources that will help them thrive

outside of school settings. At times, students can feel overwhelmed and have the pressure to do great on their courses but it can be difficult to manage if they are struggling outside of school. That is why it is essential to help them navigate those struggles and help them with their coping mechanisms. In private practice, it is beneficial for adults because it provides flexible hours and they are in charge of the time they want to start a session. Assisting therapy in a private practice will also benefit if they are focusing on reality therapy because it tends to be less than 10 sessions. This helps the client set a realistic short-term goal while also benefiting from existential therapy techniques that will benefit deeper understanding into the client's life and choices moving forward. In community settings, any individual wanting these services can go because it can benefit anybody that wants help in any aspect of their life whether it is using existential therapy, person-centered, or reality therapy. This setting will provide services with the purpose of serving the client to live a fulfilling life and let them know they are valued and heard. It will provide a safe space for anybody that needs help to overcome personal challenges.

Challenges: There are various challenges that can be faced by integrating reality therapy with two different approaches and techniques. One of the first challenges can be that individuals are not likely to accept responsibility for their choices and how it has impacted their life. If a client has a hard time accepting responsibility, it might be a challenge to implement the techniques from reality therapy such as providing them with questions “what are you doing to change?” It might be hard for the individual to recognize that they might lack motivation to do any changes to their routine to receive different outcomes, especially if there are outside factors that prevent them from changing their routine whether it is family or work-related issues. Another challenge that can be faced is that this approach might not align with people’s cultural background given that it focuses on the individual’s life and choices rather than their families. If

the person is family-oriented or their priority is the community they were raised in, it is possible they might face the challenge that this approach does not align with their beliefs.

Strengths: The strength of this integrative approach is that it has different techniques that can benefit clients whether it is focusing on the present and their actions, their existence and meaning of life, or providing a nonjudgement and empathetic approach. Each approach offers different strengths that can be combined to help the client thrive. Reality therapy will help the client set a realistic goal that can be accomplished by choosing what to do and then, they are able to reflect how that action impacted their life. In person-centered approach, it focuses on providing a non-judgmental environment where they feel safe to share anything and have a healthy client-therapist relationship. Lastly, a strength provided by existential therapy is that it helps clients reflect and explore their persona. It is important for the client to question and have a set foundation on their beliefs and themselves. This will help them identify who they truly are to their core. Integrating these three approaches to help clients will establish a healthy foundation that addresses their needs.

Case Study

Throughout the semester, I worked with a hypothetical case of a client. Kim is a 9-year-old, fourth grade student at a public school. She is the youngest of 4 siblings and does good at school except in classes that she finds boring. She often has recess taken away because she does not focus in class. She has trouble managing her emotions and expresses anger when other students do not listen to her. She expresses that she lies and makes up stories to get students to get involved. Parents have seen a decline in Kim's classes, have been serving school detention, she lies to her parents, and are having trouble motivating her. Kim also explained that she wants to do good in school, be a good student but has trouble controlling her emotions. Using the

integrative approach of reality therapy, existential therapy, person-centered therapy and focusing on themes of responsibility, regulating emotions, and motivation will benefit Kim during her therapy sessions. I would start a therapy session with Kim by building rapport and making sure that she has provided assent to start therapy. It is important to build rapport with a client because the client will feel there is a safe connection and environment where they are able to express themselves freely. Getting assent from a child is also essential for the session to run smoothly. Building rapport with Kim would be different from building rapport with a toddler. For Kim, I would be an active listener to her concerns or comments, provide a positive conversation and validate her emotions. When integrating several theoretical perspectives, I would focus primarily on reality therapy while integrating techniques from existential therapy and person-centered therapy. I would implement reality therapy by focusing on Kim's choices such as lying and maladaptive behaviors. Exploring her wants and needs using the WDEP system and developing a plan, this would help me understand what she wants, her behavior, evaluate and plan for a positive change. During the session, integrating existential therapy would come in second which will allow Kim to find meaning and become self-aware of her identity. One technique I would implement is asking questions about her values and beliefs. Finding out how she feels when other students do not listen to her, and she is not a leader would be beneficial because she would become aware of her feelings. The third approach would involve person-centered techniques that promote self-awareness and build Kim's self-esteem with positive comments. Using this approach and providing statements that validate her identity as a friend, daughter, and student will help her thrive in her environment. Validating her emotions while also providing opportunities to reflect and positively acknowledging things she's good at in school to build her self-esteem. Lastly, helping Kim develop techniques that will help her regulate her emotions is

important. One way to help Kim would be by role-playing scenarios where the counselor can be the student and vice-versa to let Kim process how she can have a positive interaction with peers in her school. Role-playing will help Kim practice her communication skills with her friends and adults, it will also allow her to reflect on her emotions when these conversations are happening. If Kim keeps on practicing her communication skills, her confidence will be boosted and that way she will do better at regulating her feelings without having outbursts. At the end of the session, Kim and I would go over the session and what she believes she can work on improving at school during the week. Acknowledging her strengths during the session is also a great technique to let Kim end her session on a positive note. Lastly, we would end the session with a positive comment and briefly discuss the following session. Doing this will push Kim to leave her session on a positive note and be optimistic that her future will improve such as having a healthy social life and reducing detention at school. Combining these three approaches of reality therapy focusing on accountability, existential therapy focusing on self-awareness, and person-centered therapy by providing positive techniques will help Kim build her confidence, self-awareness and motivate her to regulate her emotions and do better in school moving forward.

Conclusion

My integrative approach to reality therapy, existential therapy, and person-centered therapy reflects my theoretical orientation because it aligns with my beliefs, values, and previous professional work experience. Integrating these approaches made me realize that a counselor can grab techniques from different theories to implement them with the clients' needs. I have also learned that no theory is one size fits all, every individual is different and needs different techniques and approaches. I was also able to understand that every client has their own story to share. It is important to acknowledge that clients have different values in their personal life, have

gone through different experiences, and have beliefs that differ from each other. As a future counselor, it is essential to create a safe space where they will feel heard and that their experiences and emotions are being validated. Being authentic and empathetic plays a huge role in a client's session because they will feel seen. This will allow for a strong therapist-client relationship that is essential for therapy to thrive. I was also able to reflect on my values and how they have significantly changed over the years. Now, I believe that every individual is capable of change given the right environment for them to thrive where their needs and wants are being met. Although change can be difficult without a support system or because of past childhood experiences that evolved into unhealed subconscious trauma, having the resources can help an individual overcome these obstacles.

By providing existential therapy, clients will feel they are in a safe environment and be more open to sharing those traumas that are not letting them move forward with their lives and struggle with their emotions. During reality-therapy they will learn how to cope with the choices they made and look at the present and future rather than dwell on the past. This will help the client take accountability of their own life and develop self-awareness. In person-centered therapy, the client will experience a session with a positive environment, no judgment zone and that will allow them to reflect on their feelings freely without feeling shamed.

The application of my integrative theory has its limitations and strengths; however, it can be applied to almost all clients despite their cultural background, values, or beliefs. This approach can be applied to students, adults, people experiencing grief, or those from different cultural backgrounds. By integrating person-centered therapy and existential therapy, it allows clients to interact in the session without feeling judged by their values, beliefs, or culture since it provides a holistic approach. Although the limitations include not understanding their culture,

there are strengths that help overcome those challenges such as planning for a goal, self-reflection, and providing empathy to the client during the session. This approach can also be applied to three settings and benefit the individuals in them, these settings range from community, educational, and private practice.

Lastly, I was able to hypothetically implement my approach to a case study I had worked on throughout the semester. I realized that by doing this, I was able to integrate techniques that would help the client succeed. Kim would be able to reflect on her emotions, take accountability for her actions and focus on the present and future rather than dwell on her past experiences while providing help to boost her confidence and be self-aware. Building rapport with her would be essential for her to open up and express her feelings freely. I would use techniques such as role playing, WDEP system, and work on her communication skills. Then, end the session with a positive note that talked about her future goals. This integrative theory paper has helped me understand why it is important to integrate different approaches and techniques to clients, reflect on my own biases, values, and beliefs, and understand how to apply theories into a client while maintaining healthy boundaries.

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